

Lecture 8

Power, Liberalism, and World Order

13 April 2026– BAIS
International Relations



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Key Debates and Readings

Questions to be considered:

- What does the notion of ‘world orders’ bring to the study of international relations?
- Is there a crisis of the liberal world order? And why/why not?
- Is the American hegemon undermining or sustaining the liberal international order?

Required readings:

1. Heywood, A., & Whitham, B. (2023). Global politics (3rd ed., Chapter 10: Power and Twenty-First Century World Order). London: Red Globe Press.
2. Acharya, A. (2017). After liberal hegemony: The advent of a multiplex world order. *Ethics & international affairs*, 31(3), 271-285.

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**Definitions and
Relevance**



Diversity in History
of World Orders



World Orders and
Power



Crisis of the Liberal
World Order



China and the
World Order

Definitions



World Order: Definitions

*‘The actual or perceived distribution of power between and amongst states
and other key actors, giving rise to
a relatively stable pattern of relationships and behaviours’ (Heywood, 2023)*

*‘A stable pattern of relations among international actors that sustains a set of common goals
or purposes...’*

Not (to) be confused with peace or justice.’ (Roach and O’Callaghan, The Key Concepts, 2014)

Why does international order matter?

1. The nexus between international 'order' and power

- Order follows power, especially the 'balance of power' > From bipolarity to unipolarity (US hegemony), to multipolarity...
- Post Cold War: The Global Liberal Order – The scope of the liberal order varied across time, space and domain, was never universally liberal, 'ordered' or global.

2. The nexus between order and diversity

- What is at stake today: the future of the Global Liberal Order? A rules-based world? Multilateralism?
- How to sustain order in an ever more diverse world?

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The varieties of world orders



The diagram consists of five identical rectangular boxes arranged horizontally. Each box has a teal-colored top half and a light blue bottom half. The text is centered in the light blue section. The boxes are slightly offset from each other, creating a sense of depth.

Bipolar
order

Unipolar
order

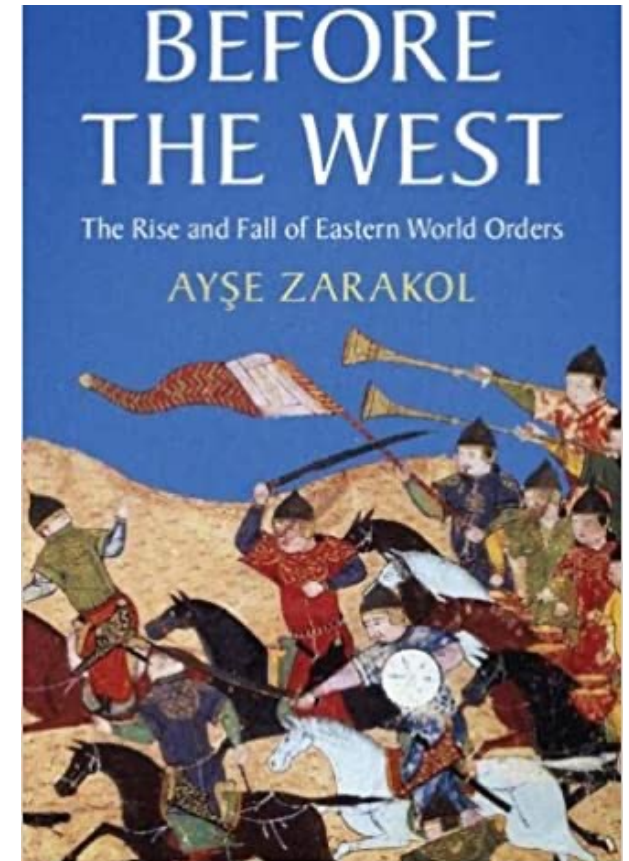
Post-
American
order

Multipolar
world order

Multiplex
world order

World orders in history

- Europe would be perceived as ‘politically fragmented’, ‘religiously intolerant’, with ‘European cities [...] overcrowded, overbuilt and ugly’ (pp. 2-3). Zarakol pushes us to learn about alternative histories, present and futures for international relations orders.
- **Eastern orders** had different norms and practices but have also had some common principles with the West. Demonstrating that sovereignty is not just a Westphalian concept, Zarakol explores its conceptualisation by the **Chingissid**, an Eastern political order and lineage starting with Genghis Khan (*Chinggis Khan*), the founder of the **Mongol Empire** that spanned between the **13th and 18th century**.
- Under the Chingissid, sovereignty ‘was marked by the extreme centralisation of power and authority in the person of the Great Khan (the supreme ruler)’ (p. 19). It also had ‘an emphasis on territorial reach and an accompanying preoccupation with astronomy and astrology’ (p. 19), as well as the role of external recognition as a legitimizing force.



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Global Power shifts

Power moving away from the national state, due to political, economic and technological developments, and its domestic and international consequences:

- From national states to regional and global institutions (regional and global governance)
- From the state to the market (globalization; technological developments)
- => Consequences: Rising levels of uncertainty, real or perceived insecurity ('precariat') and powerlessness, challenges to the welfare state, growing inequality (within rather than between societies), political alienation, migration, rise of populism, etc.

Dani Rodrik's 'impossibility theorem': democracy, national sovereignty and global economic integration are mutually incompatible. You can never have all three simultaneously and in full.

Shifting of power relations or distribution of power between states / regions:

- a) From the 'West' to the 'Rest' or the decrease of Western material (economic) and immaterial (ideational) dominance
- b) 'Emerging Powers'

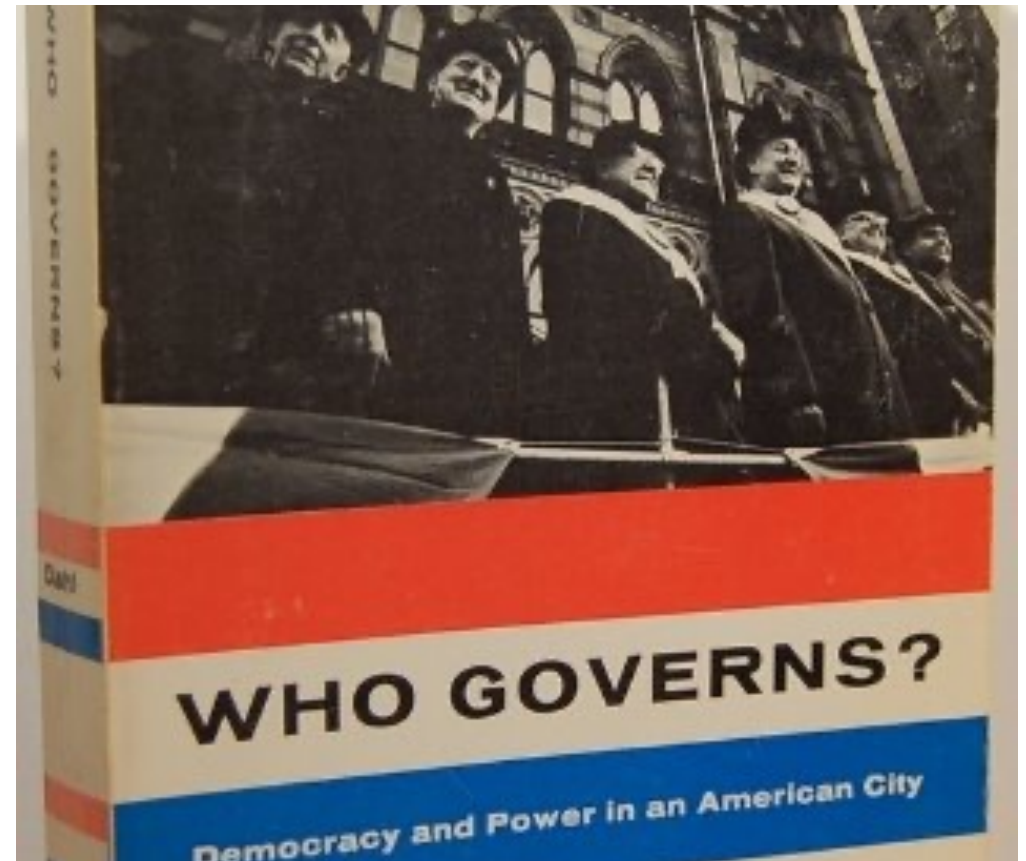
Is it Power? And what is power?

The ability to get others to do something that they would not otherwise do.

(Robert Dahl, *Who Governs? Democracy and Power in an American City*, 1961)

Pluralist State Theory : Truman 1951, Dahl, 1961, Lindblom- **the so-called Yale School**

Power is fragmented with multiple power centres and checks and balances

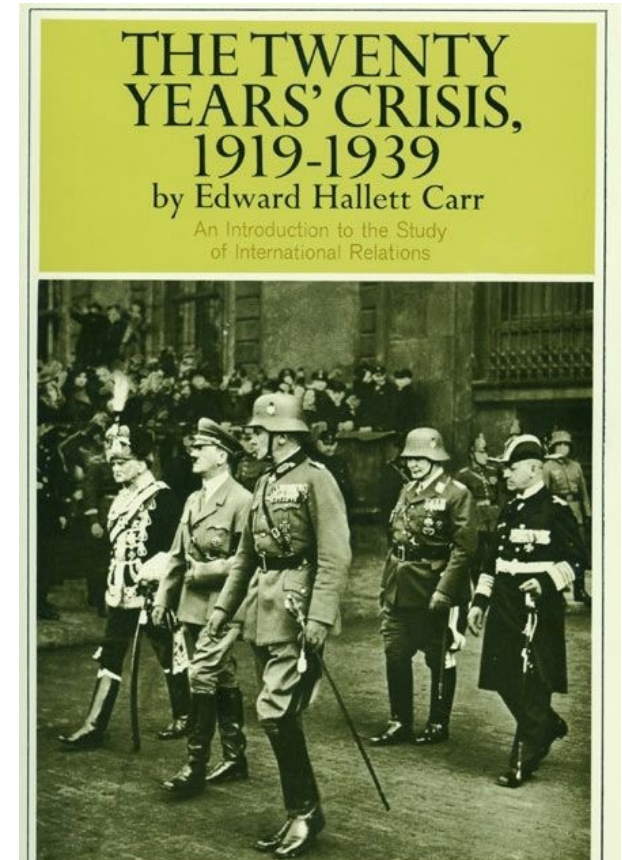


Power in global politics

Power is the 'currency' of domestic and international relations

Back to the Politics course:

- 1) **Power as 'resource' (absolute / quantitative):** About attribute, possession, control (material, immaterial power*)
 - 2) **Power as 'outcome' (relational):** About resource plus skills, strategies, and perceptions; i.e. the 'power' and influence of small(er) states
- *E.H. Carr: power over opinion (The Twenty Year's Crisis, 1919-1939: An Introduction to the Study of International Relations, London, 1939)



Power & Institutions

- "Power is embedded in institutions and changes over time through gradual institutional evolution." (Thelen, How Institutions Evolve 2004)
- Institutions:
-> ***they “are the rules of the game in a society or, more formally, are the humanly devised constraints that shape human interaction.” (North, 1990)***
- Formal and Informal Institutions
- Institutional Power-> How you shape institutions i.e. UN organisations, multilateralism

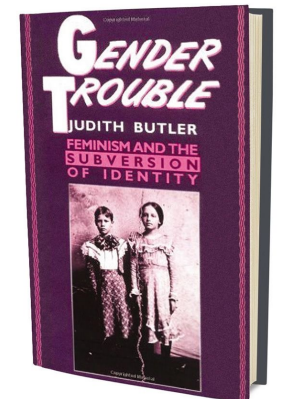
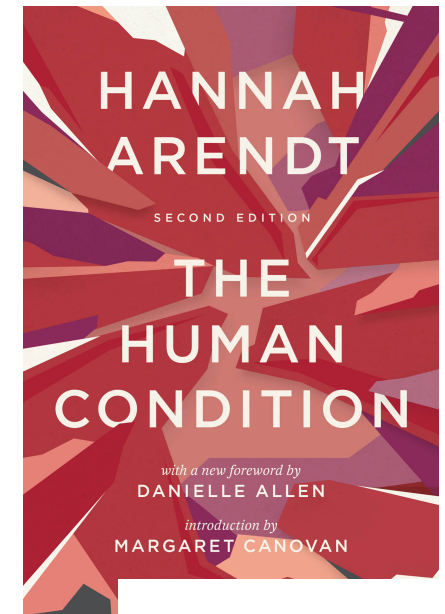
Relational Power

Power corresponds to the human ability not just to act but to act in concert. *The Human Condition* (1958).

⇒ importance of the political community

Power is not a property but a relation; it exists only in its exercise and is constitutive of the subject itself. (*The Psychic Life of Power*, 1997, p.13)

⇒ Co-constitutiveness & Relational, Performative



Hard & Soft Power (Joseph Nye)

Hard power: military + economic power –

Command power: the ability to change what other do through carrots or sticks

Tools: force, sanctions, payments

-> realist

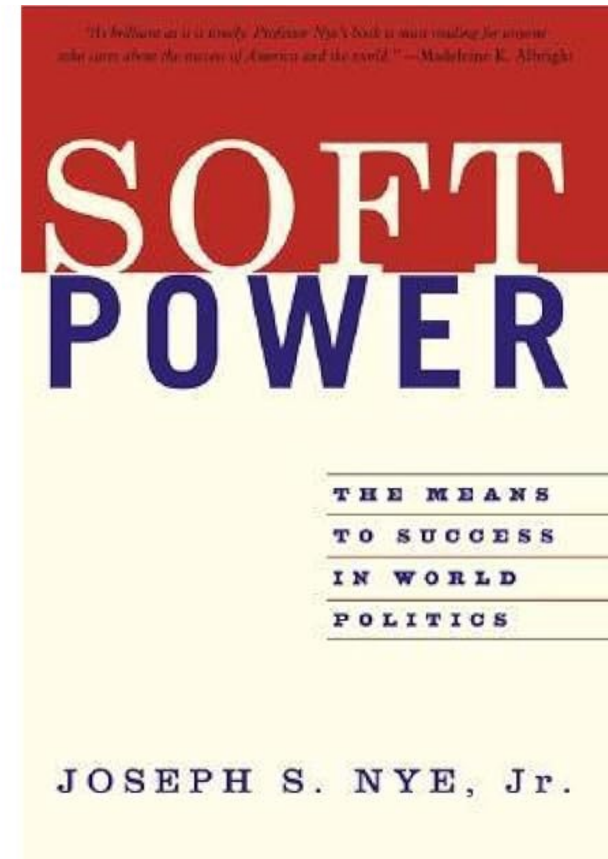
Soft power: co-optive power, attraction, importance of norms and aspirations

Tools: culture, political ideals, foreign policies

→ Liberal

Smart power: combining both

Power over vs. power with



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**Crisis of the
Liberal World
Order**



China and the
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The crisis of the Liberal World Order



Bound to Fail

John J. Mearsheimer

The Rise and Fall of the Liberal
International Order

By 2019, it was clear that the liberal international order was in deep trouble. The tectonic plates that underpin it are shifting, and little can be done to repair and rescue it. Indeed, that order was destined to fail from the start, as it contained the seeds of its own destruction.

The fall of the liberal international order horrifies the Western elites who built it and who have benefited from it in many ways.¹ These elites fervently believe that this order was and remains an important force for promoting peace and prosperity around the globe. Many of them blame President Donald Trump for its demise. After all, he expressed contempt for the liberal order when campaigning for president in 2016; and since taking office, he has pursued policies that seem designed to tear it down.

End of the Cold War and the New World (Dis)Order

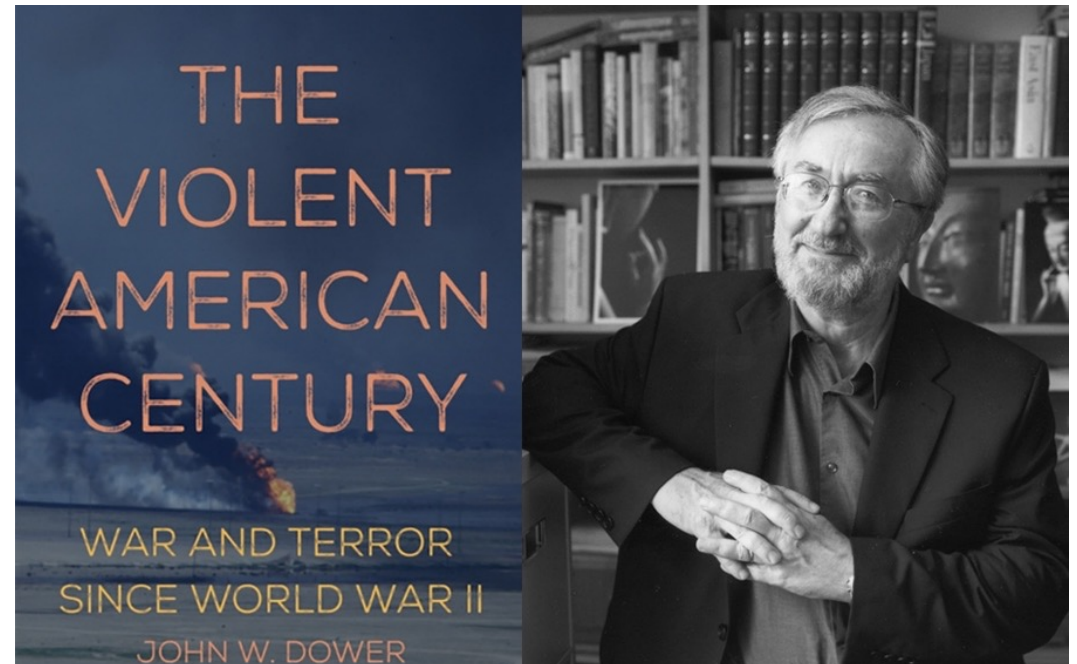
- De-ideologization of relations (Gorbachev, 1988)
- Strengthening of the UN and its peacekeeping role
- Rule of law-based order, collective security, cooperation between US and Soviet Union
- Collapse of bipolar world order that had given a sense of unity and identity to societies-> rise of fragmentation and ethnic, racial and regional conflicts.



The War on Terror

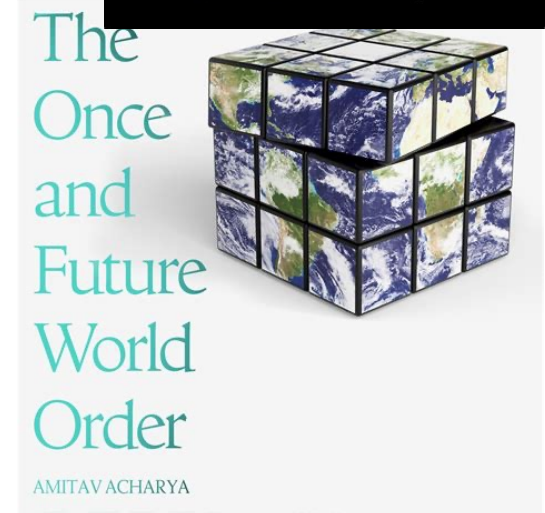
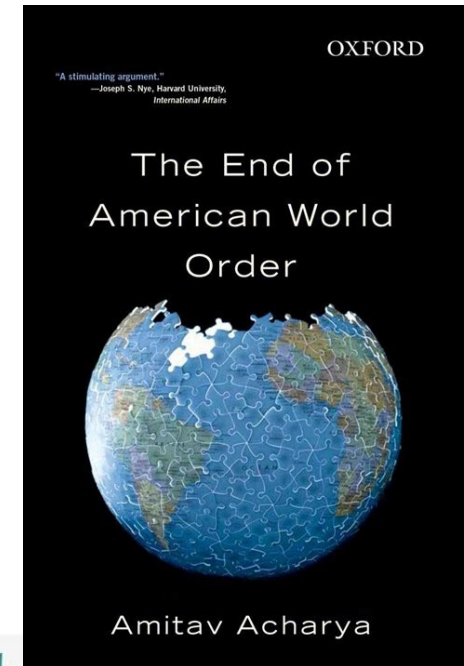
Robert Kagan (2004) put it, 'America did not change on September 11. It only became more itself.'

- Neoconservatism



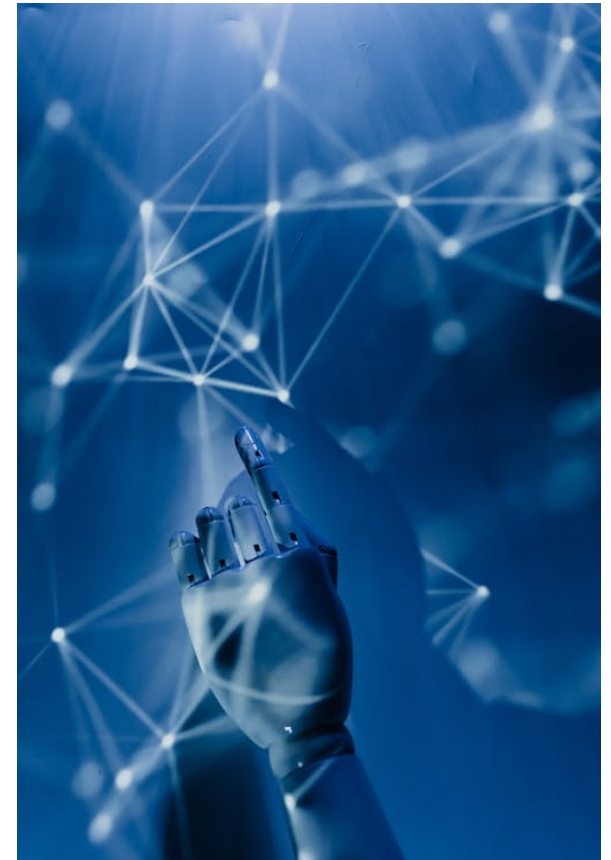
Beyond the West- Amitav Acharya

- Future world order will not be dominated by one nation or civilization
- Neither the West nor the East will get to shape the future world order
- What matters is cultural and political diversity
- New forms of connectedness and stability
- **Multiplex world order:** ‘where there are multiple shows on offer, giving the audience a choice of producers, directors, actors and plots (2025, 19)



Future of World orders

- Times of uncertainty, future global challenges climate change, pandemics, artificial intelligence
- The future is framed can empower certain actors, often transnational, to 'define political problems and devise solutions' and to shape already present decisions about the future
- From an HBIR perspective what is important **is to see how 'present futures' is socially constructed in the present.**
- Unlike futurology of what characterised what could be called science fictions, a constructivist take on present futures sees' **the future as a horizon of the present**'. (Berten J. and M. Kranke , 2022)
- This is important for a humanity-based perspective as 'humans are the architects of their own fortune'.



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Emerging powers

Emerging Powers': How to recognize them?

2 key factors:

1. **Capabilities:** economic, military and political power resources (regionally and globally), i.e. future projections based on current resources
2. **Ambitions:** belief and ambition to play a more influential role in regional and world affairs and the ambition to contribute to a revised global order – emerging powers are often revisionist powers

Russia, India and China as Emerging Powers:
'status seekers', prestige, acceptance, respect –
overcoming a century (China) / two decades (Russia)
of shame and humiliation



BRICS IN NUMBERS



BBRAZIL



RUSSIA



INDIA

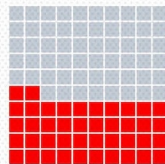


CHINA

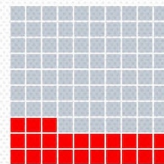


SOUTH AFRICA

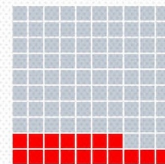
BRICS countries account for



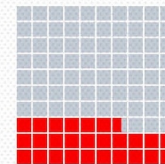
42%
of the world's
population



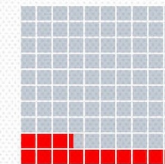
23%
of the
global GDP



17%
of the
world trade



26.6%
of world
land area



13.2%
of world
voting power

Source: News Reports

NEWS creative

Is the 21st Century the Chinese century?

How China sees the world, and its own global role:
Rising Ambitions...

- ‘Bide Time; Hide Brightness’ (Deng Xiaoping, 1980s)
- ‘Peaceful Rise’; ‘Peaceful Development’ (Hu Jintao);
- Promoting the China Model or ‘Beijing Consensus’ (from the mid-1990’s)
- Xi Jinping: the ‘Chinese Dream’, ‘Major Country Diplomacy’, a ‘New Type of Major Power Relations’, ‘China will never seek hegemony or engage in expansion’ (from the 2010s)





China and 'Global South'

China: The 'champion' of the Global South?

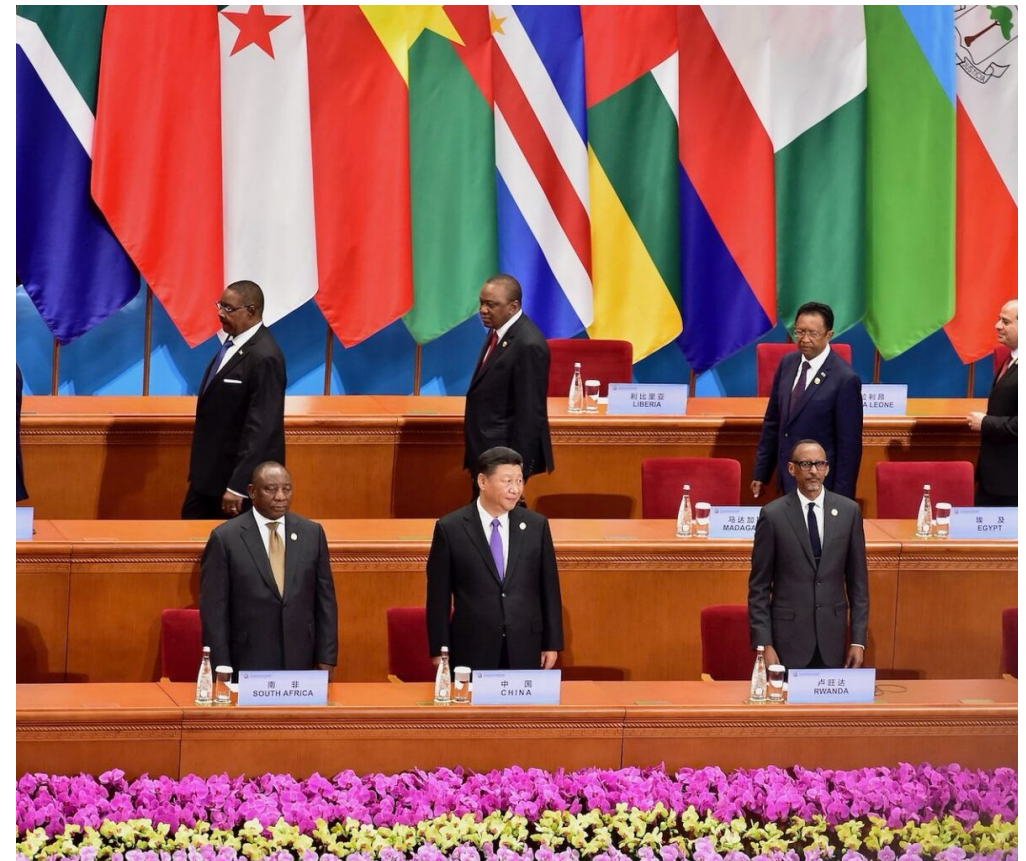
A foreign policy tradition: from the Bandung Conference (1955) and the Non-Aligned Movement (of which China was an observer) to China's 'second identity' as a developing post-colonial state (communist state as 'first identity'), to the champion of the 'Global South'. China, a 'developing country'?

Relations with the 'Global South': Asymmetric (2000-2019: share in global GDP of emerging and developing countries rose from 21 to 41 percent, of which 66% China accounted for. Comprehensive: political and economic goals are inseparable.

Interlocking, national, regional and global approaches.

Especially concessionary loans, focused on infrastructure and extraction, tied to business contracts...

2024 September: China-Africa summit

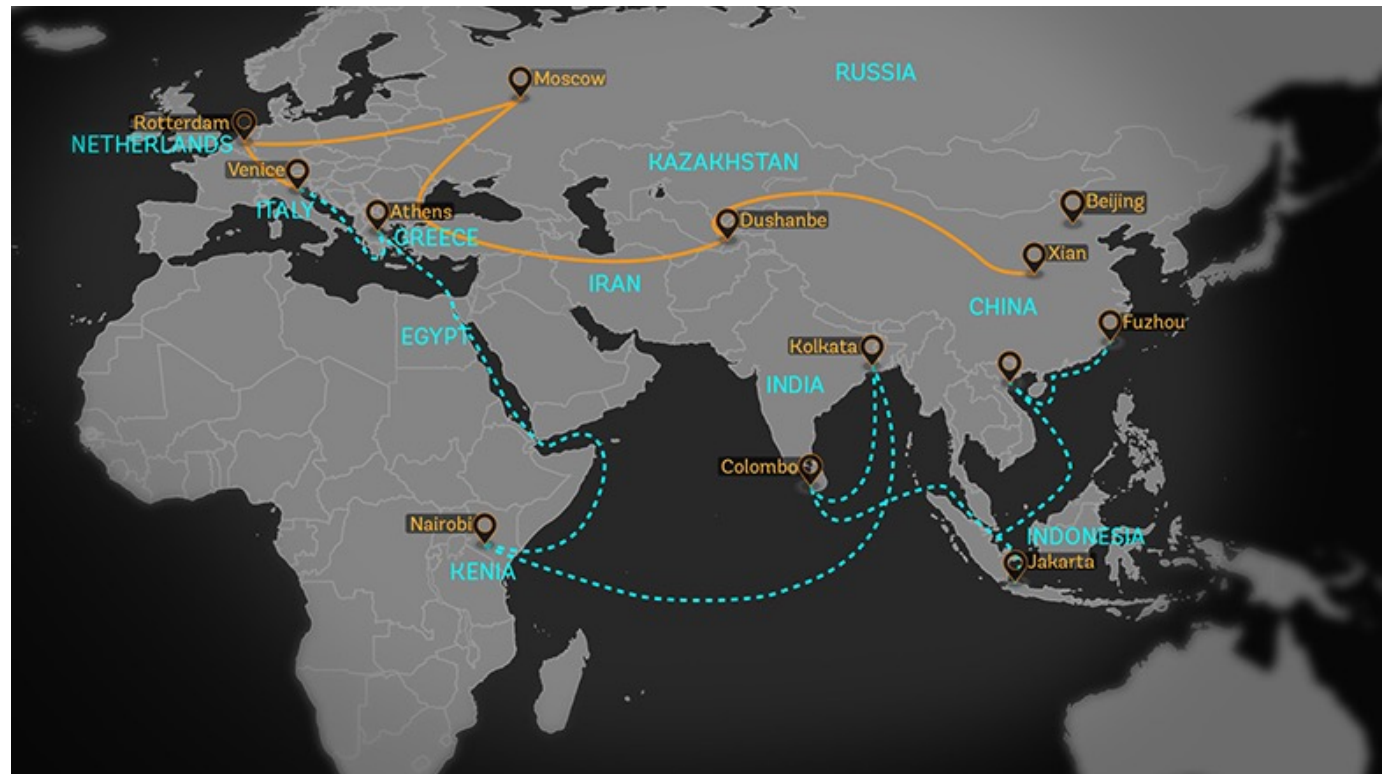


The Belt and Road initiative

[Source: World Bank](#)

President Xi Jinping's signature foreign policy initiative (announced in 2013)

- Not a multilateral institution, but a large series of bilateral agreements between China and (especially) neighbouring countries, mostly in infrastructure construction, linking China to its neighbours (Asia > Europe; South China Sea > Indian Ocean > Mediterranean)
- A lending programme to developing countries, especially through the China Development Bank > issues with burdensome terms of financing ('debt trap diplomacy')



Conclusions



World orders and their relevance to analyse IR: dynamic concepts



Strongly connected to the notion of power



They have an impact on global governance



Be aware of varieties in time and also across regions



Emerging powers and their alternatives

Week 9, April 20 – Global Governance and EU Regional Integration (Wolff)

Questions to be considered:

- What role does ‘regionalism’ bring to the study of international relations?
- What are the main theories of regional integration?
- Why has the EU been for so long as a Normative Power?

Required readings:

1. Heywood, A., & Whitham, B. (2023). Global politics (3rd ed., Chapter 10: Power and Twenty-First Century World). London: Red Globe Press.
1. Acharya, A. (2016). Regionalism beyond EU-centrism. *The Oxford handbook of comparative regionalism*, 109-13

Thank you!



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